

Law 353

Upper Athabasca Metis Medicine pouch

By, Rick Ouellet

Some time in the early spring of 2007 the elders of the community of hybrid Aboriginal/European peoples who formally inhabited Jasper National Park decided to identify as The Upper Athabasca Metis. This decision was a result of discussion with me as younger member of their community who was taking Law 353, a history of treaties in North America. A line of discourse became established that extended from an English lecture Thursday afternoons at the UBC law school, to Cree discussion along the eastern foothills of the Rocky Mountains the following week. The significance of this discourse is well understood by the Cree speaking elders whose struggles with various governing authorities has been a vexing topic for generations. They gained understanding of treaty making, both contemporary and historical, and this has invigorated them to seek alternative relationships with others who inhabit their territory, in particular the political/media approach to facilitating solutions. The information presented by Professor Jackson has resonated with the elders and they have in turn helped me with this project.

The medicine pouch is made from hand tanned deer hide. I was given a piece and instructed how to make a pouch. The materials inside were also recommended by the elders after some discussion with me. I decorated the pouch with beads and small rocks. Historically we would bring a rock from the ground where we lived. I sewed the small rocks on the front of the pouch to represent the symbolic discourse that has taken place during law 353. They are also sewed in a medicine wheel to represent the link to Cree/Metis cosmology. If

a meeting was called the rocks would act much like a talking stick. It also grounded the speaker to identify with the place that the rock came from. I thought the beads on the pull strings suited your style, thus they have no particular meaning.

Inside the pouch are a number of items that I have labeled in English, as well as a rock taken from the Adam Joachim homestead. We have talked about this site and the graves that may be impacted by a pipeline. On the rock is a hoof print of a Moose. The Cree called us Moosoyasinuik or the Moose people because we were big time Moose eaters (still are). This symbolizes that you have been indirectly communicating with the land of the Moosoyasinuik.

There are also two very common medicines included in the pouch. Mahekan Pwegeetoowon is found in small grassy areas in the foothills. It is sometimes known as a puff ball mushroom. This is a very good remedy for cuts and is not usually found in popular plant remedy guilds. Mete Muskeykey is a Heart medicine. It is a root found in mossy areas in the Rocky Mountains. Many of the elders take this regularly in teas or chewed. It is a medicine that is seen to promote a long life.

The elders have also suggested that I include smudging medicine, known to us as Neepsee Wasusqweto to burn and Tobacco or Stemass for offerings.

This medicine pouch and its contents thus represent a symbolic recognition of our relationship. I acknowledge that my education and encounters with key individuals also impacts the leadership of my community. I am personally proud of the treaty making abilities of the Iroquois side of my maternal line. I had known about Louis Kwaragkwante and his Montagnais wife Marie La Sakinaise who arrived in the eastern Rocky Mountains in the late 18th century. Their Daughter (my maternal Great-Great Grandmother) raised her extended family as the Matriarch of the Upper Athabasca River Valley, the present day location of Jasper National Park. I was however unaware, that treaty making had long been a feature of Iroquois political life. Considering the number of Aboriginal peoples whose territories meet in or near the upper Athabasca River Valley (Stoney, Cree, Shuswap, Dene), the Iroquois who migrated to the area must have been skilled negotiators.

This is the most important aspect of this class for me. I am excited to be working with the elders following a tradition that extends much farther back in time than I thought. My role as English spokesperson for the elders of the Upper Athabasca Metis is inspired by new perspectives and trailblazers such as Canassatego. Thank you Michael for your course, I offer this medicine pouch as an assignment, but also a gift to acknowledge that our time together has been very helpful to me.